STATE SCAN

RAJASTHAN: ABOVE AVERAGE WIN FOR BHAJAN LAL *PG 18*

WB: ANNAPURNA GIVETH AND TAKETH *PG 20*



DAYS OF FUTURE PAST Congress protests FIR against Rahul Gandhi, Haldwani, Sept. 2; (inset) 'purification ritual' after Kharge's visit

IANS

▶ UTTARAKHAND

ASK THE DALITS OF DEVBHOOMI

The question of caste discrimination inverts Uttarakhand's social pyramid ahead of polls. The Congress is not alone in wooing Dalits

By **Avaneesh Mishra**

It's risky in a state where privileged castes make up over half the electorate, and savarna consciousness tends to be sharply defined. But the path offers itself, as if tailormade for the Congress—a value proposition, political and moral, coherent with its positioning. The cause also got a direct and powerful symbol—the 'purification ritual' conducted by a right-wing group at the venue of party president Mallikarjun Kharge's August 8 rally in Haldwani. But after a decade of being out of power in Uttarakhand, there remains the small matter of having to win an assembly election.

As it makes caste justice central to its campaign for 2027, the challenge for the Congress is that the politics of social justice has never been a natural fit in this landscape. It must therefore blend in universal themes like jobs, education and governance. A purely caste-oriented narrative will be powerful